

LITTLE SPROUT STORIES

All Four Friends Visit the Elementary School

A story about feeling worried — and knowing friends come back together



The elementary school had a flag on top, a playground as wide as a park, and doors that seemed made for giants. Maya, Marcus, Sophie, and James stood at the bottom of the steps, looking up. Today was a special sample day — a whole day of trying out being big-school kids.

Four friends visit school.



Out came a teacher with kind eyes and a wave for every single one of them. “Welcome, explorers!” he said. “I’m Mr. Rodriguez. Today each of you will try a different classroom for a little while. Would you like to see what a teacher’s day is really like?”

Mr. Rodriguez says hello.



“Before the children arrive,” said Mr. Rodriguez, “a teacher gets everything ready.” He showed them the classroom as it wakes up: the day’s schedule written big on the board, pencils sharpened to perfect points, books laid out open and waiting, and the class plant given its morning drink of water. “My first job every day isn’t teaching. It’s preparing — so that when my students walk in, the learning can start right away.”

Mr. Rodriguez gets the room ready.



Then came the choosing. Maya went to the art room, where brushes stood in jars like flowers. Marcus went to the science room, full of magnets and mystery jars. Sophie went to the gym, echoing and enormous. And James went to the library corner, where the books seemed to whisper. Four friends, four rooms, four whole worlds inside one school.

Each friend goes to a new spot.



In the teachers' room, two teachers were practicing a science lesson on each other — pouring, fizzing, laughing when it bubbled over. "Teachers practice too?" gasped Marcus. "Of course!" said Mr. Rodriguez. "We try our lessons first, we plan together, and we talk about what worked. Good teaching isn't an accident. It's rehearsed, like a play."

Teachers practice their lessons too.



All morning, the school hummed like a friendly machine. The nurse fixed a scraped knee. The cooks rolled out lunch in great shining trays. The custodian knew which door stuck and how to fix it. And the older kids — the big, tall, almost-grown-up kids — read stories to the younger ones, one careful page at a time. “No one runs a school alone,” said Mr. Rodriguez. “It takes a whole team of helpers.”

A school has many helpers.



“Teachers teach more than reading and numbers,” Mr. Rodriguez explained as they walked the hall in a quiet line. “We teach how to line up safely, how to ask for help, how to be kind when someone is new — even how to do a fire drill, calm and quick, like we practiced.” He smiled. “The subjects matter. But so does learning how to be together.”

Teachers teach us how to be together.



But alone in the art room, with the door closed and her friends far away down the long, long hall, Maya’s heart did a strange thing. She looked at the empty chairs around her table and wondered — were her friends having more fun without her? The room that had seemed so exciting suddenly seemed very, very quiet.

Maya feels sad.

How does Maya feel at first?

- ◯ Excited
- ◯ Worried
- ◯ Angry



Then Maya remembered the bird she had seen that morning — a flash of feathers outside her window. Slowly, she picked up a brush. Dip, swish, stroke. She painted the bird’s round body, its bright eye, its morning-sky background… and as the painting grew, the worry shrank, smaller and smaller, until there was barely any left at all.

Maya paints a bird.



At lunchtime, all four friends crashed together at one big table, bursting like popcorn with stories to share. “I missed you!” said Marcus. “But the science room was SO fun — something fizzed right over the top!” Everybody talked at once, and everybody laughed, and being back together felt just as good as they knew it would.

Friends tell about their day.

What did the friends learn?

- ◯ Being apart is scary forever
- ◯ They can be apart and still come back together
- ◯ School is boring



“You know my favorite part of teaching?” Mr. Rodriguez asked as he walked them to the bus. “It isn’t the board, and it isn’t the books. It’s this: watching every child find the room where their eyes light up. Maya found hers today.” Maya held her painting a little tighter. She really, really had.

Mr. Rodriguez loves to see kids learn.



They compared their favorite parts of the day all the way to the bus — the fizzing jar, the echoing gym, the whispering books, the bird in the painting. Four friends, four adventures, one school. And tomorrow? Tomorrow they might miss each other again for a little while… and that would be perfectly okay.

It is OK to miss a friend.



■ School Explorer

Great reading!

For Grown-Ups

Feeling/skill: Separation worry eases with the certainty of reuniting.

Ask your child: What is something fun that happened when we were apart today?

Try this: Talk through the day’s schedule together before drop-off.

Words to grow on: enormous, sample, schedule, rehearse, custodian, together, worried, burst. Point at the tools as you name them — board and schedule, pencils, books, lesson plans.

The bigger picture: Teachers do much more than give lessons — they prepare their rooms and materials before students arrive, write plans and rehearse activities, work as a team with nurses, cooks, custodians, and librarians, teach safety routines and kindness alongside reading and numbers, and help every child discover what they love to learn.

Standards: RL.K.9, SL.K.4

The End — thanks for reading!